5-CARD MAJORS · STRONG NT - CORRECTED BIDDING FLOWCHART

Updated 27 Oct 2026

Letters A-H link each opening bid to its response flowchart. Points are HCP. Alertable: transfers, Smolen, McKendrick, Jacoby, 3♣/3♦ raises, weak twos, 2♣, negative and support doubles, unassuming cue bid, Helvic.

OPENING BIDS

1NT 15-17 balanced → **A**

1♥/♠ 5+ card major, 11-22 pts. **5-5: open the higher-ranking suit** (1♠ with both majors) → **B, D**

1♣/♦ no 5-card major (or a longer minor: 6-5 opens the minor, then bid the major twice): balanced 12-14 or 18-19, or unbalanced 11-22. Longer minor; 4-4 or 5-5 minors 1♦; 3-3 minors 1♣ → **C, D**

2NT 20-22 balanced → **E**

2♣ 23+ any shape, game forcing → **E**

2♦/♥/♠ weak: 5-10 HCP, 6-card suit → **E**

3-level / 4-level pre-empts: 7-card / 8-card suit, 0-10 HCP → **E**

Opponents bid (overcall or double) → **F, H**

Slam try / 4NT → **G**

A RESPONSES TO 1NT (15-17)

BALANCED hand, no major to show

0-7
Pass

8
2♠ range-ask (McKendrick)

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2♠ = 8-pt range-ask, or weak long minor (0-7). Opener 2NT = 15-16: 8 pts pass; weak hand bids 3♣/3♦ to play. Opener 3♣ = 17: 8 pts bid 3NT; weak clubs pass, weak diamonds 3♦.

9
2NT invite

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Opener: 15 pass; 16-17 bid 3NT

10-15
3NT

16-17
4NT quantitative 18+: slam try

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Opener: 15 pass; 16-17 bid 6NT

UNBALANCED hand / holding a major

2♣ STAYMAN - 8+ with a 4-card major (or 5-4 in the majors). Opener: **2♦** no 4-card major · **2♥** 4♥ (may hold 4♠) · **2♠** 4♠ and ≤3♥.

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After 2♦: 2NT = 8-9 invite (15 pass, 16-17 3NT) · 3NT = 10+ · **SMOLEN: 3♥ = 5♠+4♥, 3♠ = 5♥+4♠** (game force; opener bids 4 of the 5-card major with 3+ cards, else 3NT) · weak 5-4 (0-7): 2♥/2♠ to play.

After 2♥/2♠ (fit): 3M invite 8-9 (16-17 → 4M, 15 pass) · 4M 10+. **No fit:** 2NT 8-9 · 3NT 10+. After 2♥ with 4♠ only: 2♠ = game force (opener 4♠ with four, else 3NT). Weak 5-4: pass the fit.

2♦ → 2♥ · 2♥ → 2♠ TRANSFERS - 5+ card major, any strength. Opener completes. (Jump transfers removed: opener could never accept an invitation.)

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After a completed transfer: pass 0-7 · 2NT = 5-card suit, invite 8-9 (opener: 15 pass, or 3M with 3+; 16-17 3NT, or 4M with 3+) · 3M = 6+ cards, invite 8-9 (16-17 → 4M) · 3NT = 5-card suit, 10-14 (opener passes, or corrects to 4M with 3+) · new suit = slam try (forcing).

4♦ → 4♥ · 4♥ → 4♠ TEXAS - 6+ major, 10+, to play.

Invites: 15 = minimum, 16-17 = accept.

Slam: 4NT quantitative (balanced) · transfer then new suit · once a fit is found 4NT = RKCB with 31+ combined (see G).

B RESPONSES TO 1♥/♠

3 trumps

3 trumps: 2M 6-9 · 3M 10-12 · 13+: new suit (forcing), then support. **4M = weak, 5+ trumps** (to play).

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After 2M: 11-15 pass · 16-18 3M try (8-9 or ≤8 losers → 4M, else pass) · 19+ 4M · **by losers: 6 → 3M, ≤5 → 4M**.

After 3M: 15+ 4M (31+ combined → 4NT, G) · 13-14 use LTC · 11-12 pass (≤6 losers: 4M).

4+ trumps

4+ trumps: 3♦ = 7-9 · 3♣ = 10-12 · 2NT Jacoby = 13+ (game force).

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After 3♦: 11-15 sign off 3M · 16+ 4M.

After 3♣: 11-13 sign off 3M · 14+ 4M.

JACOBY 2NT - opener bids: 4 new suit = good 5-card side suit · else 3 of a singleton/void · 3NT 15-17 flat · 4M 11-14 flat · **18+ with 2+ key cards: 4NT at once** (31+ combined), else 3M 18+ flat.

0-2 trumps

0-2 trumps: over 1♥: 1♠ with 4+♠ (6+, forcing) · **1NT 6-10, any shape, not forcing** · new suit at 2-level 9+ (forcing). Opener rebids: see D.

C RESPONSES TO 1♣/♦

New suit - longest (if equal, lowest; over 1♣ with 4♦ and a 4-card major, bid the major): 1-level 6+ pts · 2-level 9+ pts. Forcing, **no upper limit**: a 16+ hand starts here and makes slam tries.

1NT 6-10 balanced, no 4-card major.

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Opener: 11-15 rebid 6-card suit or show a new 4-card suit · 18-19 bal 2NT · 15-19 unbal jump or support.

2NT 11-12 balanced, no major.

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Opener: pass with 11-12 · 3NT with 13+ · else support or rebid.

After 18-19 2NT: 6-7 pass · 8-10 3NT. After a 15-19 jump or support: 8-10 bid game.

3NT = 13-15 balanced, no major. With 16+ balanced: new suit first, then 4NT quantitative.

D OPENER'S REBID (new-suit reply)

Balanced: 12-14 → 1NT (2NT after a 2-level response) · 18-19 → 2NT (3NT after a 2-level response).

Unbalanced 11-14 "weak": simple raise (4+) 1♣-1♥-2♥ · new suit below the barrier 1♣-1♥-1♠ (**6-4: major first**) · simple rebid of a 5+ suit 1♠-2♥-2♠.

Unbalanced 15-19 "strong" (or 7-card suit / ≤5 losers)**:** double raise 1♣-1♥-3♥ · reverse (above the barrier) 1♦-1♠-2♥ · jump rebid of a 6+ suit 1♠-2♥-3♠ · 6-5 (minor opened): show the major.

Unbalanced 20-22: jump shift 1♣-1♥-2♠, game forcing.

Responder then: after weak: 13+ game, 11-12 invite, ≤10 pass or correct (over 2M, Hx = support: 10-12 3M) · after strong: 10+ game, 6-9 sign off · after jump shift: never pass · after 1NT (12-14): 11-12 2NT, 13+ 3NT, ≤10 pass · after 2NT (18-19): 7+ game, else pass. With a fit and 31+ combined: 4NT (G).

Barrier = 2 of the opening suit; a new suit above it (reverse) shows extra strength. 5-5: open the higher, then show the lower.

E 2NT · 2♣ · WEAK TWOS · PRE-EMPTS

2NT 20-22 bal: pass 0-3 · 3NT 4+ · 3♣ Stayman (opener 3♦/3♥/3♠; then 4M with a fit, else 3NT) · 3♦/3♥ transfers (then pass 0-3; 4-5: **3NT = choice** with exactly 5, opener corrects to 4M with 3+; else 4M) · 4♦/4♥ Texas.

2♣ 23+: 2♦ negative 0-7 · positive 8+: 4+ suit 2♥/♠ or 5+ minor 3♣/♦; bal 8-9 2NT, 10-12 3NT. Opener after 2♦: 2♥/♠ 5+ suit · 3♣/♦ 5+ minor · 2NT 23-24 bal (0-1 pass, else as over 2NT) · 3NT 25-27 bal.

Weak two (5-10 HCP, 6-card suit). Responder: pass (2-card, under 14) · 3M with 3 trumps · 4M with 4+ trumps · **2NT ask with 14+**. Opener: 3M = minimum or no feature · bid an outside A/K = feature (8-10) · 3NT = solid AKQ suit.

Pre-empts: 3♣-3♠ = 7-card suit · 4♣-4♠ = 8-card suit · 0-10 HCP. Partner: change suit only if longer; with 3-4 top honours raise to game. **Over an opposing pre-empt (12+):** 6-card suit overcall at the 3-level, 7-card suit at the 4-level; double = takeout (3+ in all unbid suits).

F COMPETITIVE AUCTIONS · DOUBLES

Overcalls: 1-level 5+ good suit, 8+ · 2-level 6+ suit, 10+ · weak jump 6+ suit, 6-10 (partner raises to the fit's level: 3 with 3, 4 with 4) · **1NT 15-18** balanced with a stopper.

Takeout double: 12+ (or 11 with perfect shape), 3+ cards in every unbid suit. Advancer: **4-card major first**, else longest suit · 0-8 lowest · 9-11 jump · **12+ cue-bid their suit** (GF): doubler shows a 4-card major, else 2NT with a stopper, else a minor; advancer picks the game (own 5-card major: 3-level, forcing). Never pass unless RHO bids.

NEGATIVE DOUBLE (partner opens, RHO overcalls, through 3♠). Shows the unbid major(s): 4♠ over 1m-(1♥) · 4♥ over 1m-(1♠) · 4-4 majors over 1♣-(1♦) · both minors over 1♥-(1♠). Points: 6+ (1-level), 8+ (2-level), 10+ (3-level). Opener: natural; jump = max; cue = GF. **Weak (4-8), 5+ in opener's minor: pre-emptive jump raise.**

PENALTY DOUBLE: double of an overcall at the 4-level or higher · double of a 1NT overcall, 8+ · with a trump stack at a lower level, pass; if partner reopens with a double, leave it in (reopening: see H).

REDOUBLE after RHO doubles partner's opening: 10+, no fit, penalty-minded. If they run: double with 4+; **pass is forcing**, so redoubler doubles or bids (5-5: higher first, as it shows 5+ there, unless the lower has 2 of AKQ and the higher none). Otherwise bid naturally.

Our 1NT opening doubled: 2♦/♥/♠ natural sign-off (transfers off; 5-5: bid the lower) · redouble 7+ · *or Helvic (H)*. **Our 1NT overcall doubled:** systems on (Stayman, transfers) · redouble 8+, penalty-minded.

CAPPELLETTI vs their strong 1NT (8+ pts): **X** = penalty (16+ or a running suit) · **2♣** one-suiter (partner relays 2♦; pass with diamonds, else name it) · **2♦** both majors · **2♥** hearts + a minor · **2♠** spades + a minor · **2NT** both minors.

MICHAELS cue bid (5-5; weak 6-10 or strong 16+): over 1♣/♦ = both majors · over 1♥/♠ = the other major + a minor (advancer bids 2NT to ask the minor). **UNUSUAL 2NT** = the two lowest unbid suits, 5-5, same strengths.

G SLAM TOOLS

RKCB 4NT (only once a trump suit is agreed; otherwise quantitative). Key cards = 4 aces + the K of trumps. Replies: **5♣ 0 or 3 · 5♦ 1 or 4 · 5♥ 2 without Q · 5♠ 2 with Q**.

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Asker: missing two key cards → 5 of trumps · missing one → 6 of trumps · all five → 5NT (asks kings; show each king by bidding its suit in order). Cheapest non-trump bid asks for the trump Queen. **Warning:** with hearts trumps a 5♠ reply is past 5♥, so asker can only go 6♥ or 5NT.

WHEN TO ASK: once a fit is found, your points + partner's shown minimum = **31+ → 4NT**. Ask only with **2+ key cards** yourself; with 0-1, bid game and let partner ask. Unclear reply (0 or 3, 1 or 4): work it out. With 31+ between you, the opponents can't hold 3 key cards (11+ pts), so 0/3 = 3; with 2+ yourself, 1/4 = 1. **Grand:** all five key cards + trump Q + a side king.

LOSING TRICK COUNT (8+ card suit fit only, never NT). **24 − (opener losers + responder losers) = tricks; level = tricks − 6.** E.g. 24 − 14 = 10 tricks → 4-level. HCP→losers is approximate: count real losers when shape is unusual. **In every auction with a fit, competitive too, shape counts: if losers give 10 tricks (11 in a minor), bid game even when points say stop.**

Opener	
Points	**Losers**
11	8
12-14	7
15-17	6
18-19	5
20-22	4
23+	3

Responder	
Points	**Losers**
0-5	10
6-9	9
10-11	8
12-15	7
16+	6

H SUPPORT DOUBLES · CUE BIDS · HELVIC · AFTER A PENALTY DOUBLE

SUPPORT DOUBLE (the "positive" double): 1♣/♦/♥ – 1♥/♠ – (overcall up to 2 of responder's suit) – **X = exactly 3-card support**. If RHO doubled: **XX = exactly 3**. With 4+, raise (11-14 simple, 15-19 double raise).

Responder after the support double: 0-9 cheapest bid in the major · 10-12 jump to 3M (or 2NT with 4 cards and a stopper) · 13+ 4M (or 3NT with 4 cards and a stopper). Opener accepts an invitation with 13+ or ≤6 losers.

UNASSUMING CUE BID (partner overcalls): cue-bid opener's suit = 3+ support, 10+ (limit raise or better) · simple raise 3+, 6-9 · jump raise 4+, 4-8 (pre-emptive). Overcaller: cheapest rebid of the suit = minimum (8-12), jump to game = 13+ or ≤6 losers. Advancer then bids game with 13+. A *direct* cue bid is still Michaels.

HELVIC WRIGGLE (option when our 1NT is doubled): **pass** = 7+ values (pass the forced redouble) or a wriggle (after opener's forced XX, bid 4-card suits up the line) · **XX** = weak one-suiter (opener bids 2♣, pass or correct) · **2♣/2♦/2♥** = this suit + the next one up. Opener: pass with 3+ in the suit shown, else bid the next suit up.

OPENER REOPENING (their overcall passed round): 3+ in their suit pass · 5-card second suit: bid it · 6+ own suit: rebid · else short in theirs: **double**. **AFTER OUR PENALTY DOUBLE / REDOUBLE:** double their escape with 4+ cards in it. **After we double their 1NT:** partner leaves it in unless 0-4 with a 5+ suit (take out, to play). If they run: double with 4+ in their suit, weak with a 5+ suit bid it, otherwise pass (forcing); doubler then doubles with 3+ or bids his longest suit.

Opening · Response · Opener rebid · Convention · Competitive · Note

Print on A3, or scale to fit A4. Arrows show the order of the auction.